

Robbing yourself?

INSTEAD OF BEING JUST CONSUMERS, you and me are also donning the hat of unwitting accomplice in some of the biggest scams that are being perpetrated right now! I'll get to an explanation of how that is in a minute.

In 2019, when the amount of money spent on ads worldwide is estimated to be roughly 650 billion USD, for the first time ever, will over half of that be spent on digital platforms. This is according to a report by emarketer.com. An estimated \$333 billion will be spent in 2019 on digital ads, and about a third of that will go to Google (\$103 billion). Facebook will be a distant second at about 67 billion, Alibaba will get 29 billion, Amazon will earn 14 billion, etc. Needless to say, it's a pie that's growing fast, and more and more people want a part of it, especially if said piece can be gotten easily.

Methods of getting you to click on rubbish have long since moved on from the good old days of email spam – never thought I'd find myself calling the email spam days 'good'! That was replaced with what is known as GIVT. It stands for General InValid Traffic, which is essentially just robots pretending to be human and clicking links and visiting websites, and the like. Even legitimate search engine crawlers are considered GIVT, because they are useless to advertisers. Bots which spend 24 hours a day clicking hundreds of thousands of links used to be able to fool ad networks, and artificially raise money for evil web sites who wanted to inflate traffic figures and ad clicks. However, the ad industry soon used technology against itself to catch this out.

Now we have what's called SIVT – sophisticated invalid traffic. This is the traffic that often has cheap human labour behind it, or very smartly programmed bots that attempt to mimic real humans and their behaviours. Perhaps watching hours of cat videos and then liking posts of pages that paid them. Perhaps it's as simple as actually scrolling and spending time on pages that mimics reading before clicking on an ad, and of course, being logged into fake social media accounts also helps.

While GIVT is no trouble, SIVT keeps finding inventive ways in which to game the system, and one of those ways is by compromising your phone. This is where I come back to the part about you being an unwitting accomplice to fraud. You see a friend share a game that looks

addictive, or you see an ad on a social network for the game. You install it, just accept all the permissions it asks for, and get to playing it. It's pretty addictive for a while, but eventually you bore of it. Doesn't have to be a game, it could be any sort of app. Problem is, you gave it permission to run in the background, and boy, does it! It requests ads, simulates clicks, and does it all in the background. Not only is this possible, it's been happening for some time, and new developers are caught doing this all the time.

In February 2019, Oracle discovered and reported a bot that they called 'DrainerBot', which was a mobile ad fraud bot that was downloading and pretending to display video ads in apps that weren't even run by users. All happening in the background, this led to not just battery drain, but also data usage in some cases of up to 10 GB a month! Read more about it here: <https://dgit.in/DrainerBot>

Ad fraud is roughly estimated to be at least a 20 billion dollar market, with some estimates going as high as \$40 billion. That's a lot of money just waiting to be earned by developers with no morals, but of course, you're the middle man here. None of this is possible without you and me, and it relies on us using apps from unknown (usually Chinese) developers who are a dime a dozen.

Why should you care if rich advertisers are being ripped off? Because those same rich advertisers always make their money back, always! They just charge us more for their products and services, which we need or want. In the end, it's like we're being accomplices in the goal of picking our own pockets! All we need to do is be a lot more careful about what we install, and make sure we only do it from trusted sources. Surely that's not a hard ask is it?

While you're at it, please also make sure to whitelist the dgit.in domain in your ad blocker, and when you want to buy something, find it on our site and use our affiliate links. We really could use the support, since we don't use any nefarious techniques such as GIVT, SIVT or any IVT for that matter... 



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